

dled bad blood in the party. Many started demanding tickets for their wives at the cost of genuine workers."

Now he is doing things differently—from walking the streets and rubbing shoulders with the common man to letting party workers hop on to the stage, he is clearly going the extra mile to create new foot soldiers. In November 2009, the stage at a meeting caved in because of overcrowding, leaving the RJD chief with a

room, the one talking for the people. The last few months have seen the emergence of a new Lalu—the one who makes calls to his supporters, who is not afraid of criticising his own party and who does not carry family baggage. Even the man who answers the telephone at his residence cautiously says a polite "namaskar"

KUMAR (RIGHT) AND DEPUTY CHIEF MINISTER SUSHIL MODI



hairline fracture in his right ankle. He continued to address the meeting. Later, he campaigned in Jharkhand, limping along with a walking stick. It was painful, but it steeled his resolve.

On January 28, he enforced a hugely successful Bihar bandh to protest rising prices, walking through Patna. His words have taken a softer tone now. His demeanour, poise and desperation to reach out to the people speaks volumes. He is delivering his best speeches perhaps because this is, so far, his worst moment. He does not lecture, nor deliver a homily, a reminder of how things ought now to be. He conjures up images of a new Bihar where things will work.

He seems to speak so commonsensical and maturely that sometimes he seems to be only adult in the

instead of the erstwhile gruff "hello".

But beyond the posturing, Lalu is battling many demons, some in his mind as well. The man who over 50 MLAs swear their unflinching loyalty to, the man of the masses, the man on whom realms have been written, is increasingly becoming a loner. And the man behind the persona is anguished and crestfallen. "I have never harmed anyone. Yet all of them are out trying to finish me. That pains me," he admits. But he no longer has the luxury of true friends with whom

he can share his travails with; all he has is crowd of wannabe consiglieres.

But perhaps Lalu never had anyone to fall back upon; all he had were followers and fair-weather friends and he is realising today after many trusted lieutenants left him to join the enemy camp when the chips were down. Does he still believe in friendship? He flashes an ironical smile, injury within his eyes. "I tell my son to look beyond the words said to him. Relatives, friends; all have stabbed me in the back. I trusted them so much. Sometime I wonder why the earth doesn't swallow me," he says as he slips into a ruminating mood. There is no antidote. "Things will change," he declares after a ponderous moment.

Lalu knows that he cannot afford to remain occupied with Kumar as his personal and political decisions will impact his world, namely Bihar. The crafty politician in him seems to have realised that under the current circumstances, price rise was a bigger issue to kick off his campaign with than other concerns like law and order, division of the Dalits and the confusion over implementation of the land reforms commission report in the state.

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All said and done, staging a comeback is far tougher than sailing through. A large section of the people suspects that he has not really changed and has only slipped into campaign mode, reaching for the rhetoric when he might be better advised to concen-

trate on genuinely representing the masses that he seeks to represent.

These are early days, but Lalu is finding out the hard way that simply not being an arrogant man is an insufficient condition for success, however charismatic he may be. And even that is being put to the test. ■